

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 810

By Massey

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of James "Jim" Moore Hart of Knoxville.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of James "Jim" Moore Hart of Knoxville; and

WHEREAS, Jim Hart was an exemplary public servant and consummate professional who worked assiduously to improve the quality of life for his fellow citizens in numerous capacities; and

WHEREAS, born in Knoxville, Mr. Hart attended Webb School of Knoxville and was a member of the school's first graduating class; he went on to graduate from Davidson College in 1965; and

WHEREAS, during his sophomore year, Jim Hart met Jan Cummins, a student at Sullins College in Bristol, Virginia, and married her shortly thereafter; this began a partnership that would span nearly sixty-four years; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Hart's family had deep roots in the broadcasting and civic life of Knoxville; John Hart, Mr. Hart's father, helped the WBIR founder, Jesse W. Birdwell, start the station on AM radio in 1941; John Hart later became part of the station's original television ownership group and was WBIR's general manager when it launched on TV in 1956; and

WHEREAS, Jim Hart was by his father's side in the station's early days and began his own career as a sales executive at WBIR; he held general manager roles for television stations in Winston-Salem, North Carolina, and Cincinnati, Ohio, before returning to Knoxville as general manager for WBIR in 1981, serving in the position for nearly thirteen years; and

WHEREAS, while serving as general manager, Mr. Hart developed WBIR's "Straight from the Heart" brand, which continues as the station's motto today; he also launched "The Heartland Series," a longtime award-winning program that shared the stories of the Smokies

and Appalachian culture and supported one of his main missions of celebrating the people of East Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, in 1994, Jim Hart left WBIR and began leading several television and radio stations as president of Multimedia, Inc.; he later served as senior vice president of Scripps-Howard and then vice president for the E.W. Scripps Company, where he oversaw operations at thirteen television affiliates across the country; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Hart retired from broadcasting at the age of sixty in 2001; throughout his career, colleagues and staff consistently described him as a respected and supportive leader who earned the loyalty of those with whom he worked; and

WHEREAS, upon retiring, Jim Hart began a second career in nonprofit leadership; in 2002, he began serving as president of Friends of the Smokies, playing a critical role in building enduring fundraising events and advocacy efforts to preserve and protect the Great Smoky Mountains National Park; under his leadership, Friends of the Smokies created the specialty license plate program that raises millions of dollars for the park each year; and

WHEREAS, in addition to his love for East Tennessee and the Smoky Mountains, Mr. Hart was a lifelong Tennessee Volunteers football fan and followed the program faithfully throughout his life; and

WHEREAS, Jim Hart was deeply devoted to his family, and he always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Hart is survived by his wife of nearly sixty-four years, Jan Hart; children, Jennifer Hart (Bob Cook), James M. (Catherine) Hart II, John Hart (Alicia Renfroe); three grandchildren, Leah, Cassie, and Christopher Hart; sister, Anne Hart; and niece, Katherine (Jason Strickland); and a host of colleagues and friends; and

WHEREAS, Jim Hart was a passionate soul, who invested deeply and with his whole heart in things he loved; he greatly impacted the lives of those who were blessed to know him, and he leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all his chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of James "Jim" Moore Hart, reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family, friends, and colleagues of Mr. Hart.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.